



Scam Smart

Spotting the cons that target older adults — and shutting them down

A 25-minute conversation about money, trust, and the one habit that stops almost all of it

Two things before we start

1

This is not about being gullible.

These crews are trained, scripted, and paid to do this all day. Falling for one is not a sign that anything is wrong with you — it's a sign a professional got to you.

2

You do not need to learn 40 scams.

Every scam on the next 20 slides runs the same three-step play. Learn the play once, and you can catch a scam that hasn't been invented yet.

Last year, Americans 60 and older reported losing

\$7.75 billion

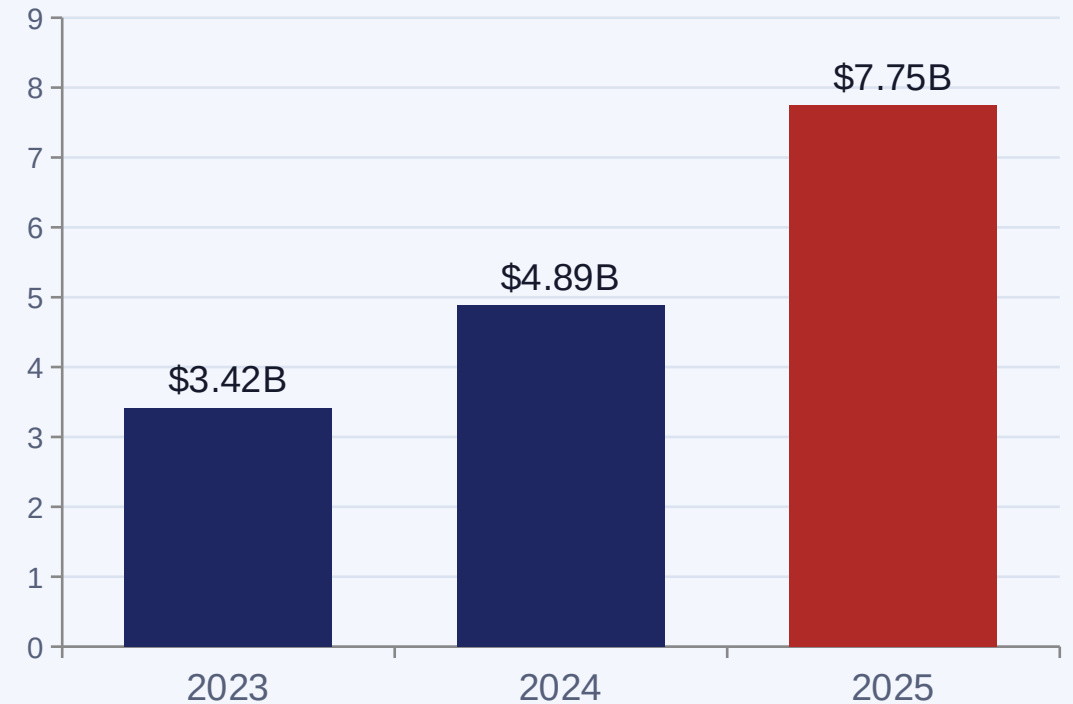
to online scams — a 59% jump in a single year.



And that is only what got reported.

The FBI says the true total is almost certainly much higher, because many people never report — out of embarrassment, or not knowing where to call.

Reported losses, age 60+ (billions)



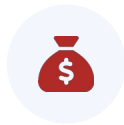
WHY THIS ROOM

You are 20% of the complaints — and 37% of the money



201,266

complaints filed by people 60+ in 2025



\$38,501

average loss per victim — nearly
double every other age group



#2

Texas ranks second in the nation for
complaints, behind only California



Why older adults specifically?

Not because of confusion. Because you have savings, home equity, good credit, a landline, and — the trait they exploit hardest — you were raised to be polite to strangers and to take a phone call seriously.

You are not up against "a guy."

You're up against an industry with buildings, shifts, and quotas.



Call centers

Whole floors of workers reading tested scripts, with supervisors coaching in their ear when you hesitate.



AI tools

Cloned voices from a few seconds of audio. Perfect grammar. Fake photos and video used as "proof."



Bought data

Your details are already for sale. We will look at exactly where that comes from next.



Instant payout

Crypto, wires, and gift cards move money overseas in minutes — before anyone can call it back.

BEFORE THE PHONE EVEN RINGS

How do they know so much about you already?



Data breaches

Companies you did business with get hacked. Your name, email, phone, and old passwords end up on lists that get traded and resold for years.



Data brokers

Legal companies buy and sell your age, address, phone number, income bracket, and your relatives' names. Pennies per record.



Social media

Grandchildren's names, your birthday, when you're away — and a few seconds of someone's voice, which is all a cloning tool needs.



Public records

Property records, church bulletins, and obituaries hand over family names, relationships, and addresses — all free to look up.

So a caller knowing your name, your bank, or your grandson's name proves nothing at all.

IF YOU REMEMBER ONE SLIDE, MAKE IT THIS ONE

Every single scam runs this same three-step play

1

Unexpected contact

They reach you. A call, text, pop-up, email, or friend request you didn't ask for.

2

A spike of emotion

Fear, love, urgency, or excitement. Something to stop you thinking and start you reacting.

3

An odd way to pay

Gift cards, wire, crypto, cash by courier, gold. Or "just move it to a safe account."



All three at once? It's a scam. Every time. You don't need to figure out which one.

Phishing: the most common one you'll see



A message that impersonates someone you trust

- Your bank, Amazon, Medicare, the post office, Apple, your church.
- "Suspicious charge — click to verify." "Your package couldn't be delivered." "Your account will be closed."
- The link goes to a copy of the real website. You type your password in, and now they have it.
- Newest twist: a fake "product recall" with a refund link.

The rule: never use the link. Go to the website yourself, or call the number on your card or statement.

48,064

complaints from people 60+ in 2025 — more than any other scam type, and more than double the year before.

\$77 million

lost — which is small next to the others. Phishing usually isn't the theft. It's the front door to it.

Tech support: the pop-up that won't go away

\$1.04 billion lost by older adults in 2025 — the second-costliest scam in this room.

1

The scare

A loud pop-up, alarm sound, or frozen screen: "VIRUS DETECTED — call Microsoft now." Sometimes it's just a cold call.

2

The access

They talk you into installing software so they can "fix it." Now they're driving your computer and watching your screen.

3

The look-around

They ask you to log into your bank "to check for damage." They're shopping — picking the account with the most in it.

4

The ask

A fee, gift cards, or a transfer. Often they'll "accidentally refund too much" and ask you to send the difference back.



Microsoft, Apple, and Google will never call you. Ever. There is no exception to this.

The Phantom Hacker: a three-act play with three actors

ACT I

"Tech support"

Your computer is infected. Let me in to check. Now log into your accounts so we can look for damage.

ACT II

"Your bank's fraud department"

A foreign hacker is inside your accounts. Your money isn't safe here. Move it to a secure account we've set up.

ACT III

"A federal official"

This is an active investigation. Don't discuss it with family or your branch. Here's our letterhead to prove it.

No bank and no government agency will EVER ask you to move money to keep it safe.



\$1 billion+

stolen this way since 2024, per FBI warnings.

All three "people" are the same crew.

Victims often lose checking, savings, and retirement — all of it — believing they were protecting it.

Government impersonation: badges and threats



Who they claim to be

- Social Security — "your number has been suspended"
- Medicare — "we need to reissue your card"
- IRS — "you owe back taxes, pay today"
- Local police — "there's a warrant for a missed jury summons"

8,628

older adults reported this in 2025 — nearly double the 4,521 who reported it in 2024. It is the fastest-climbing scam aimed at this age group.



Four things the real government never does:

- Call and threaten you with immediate arrest
- Ask to be paid in gift cards, crypto, wire, or cash in the mail
- Tell you to keep the matter secret from your family
- Demand you stay on the line while you go to the bank

Romance and friendship scams: the long con



It doesn't start with money. That's the point.

- It may begin as friendship, faith, or a shared hobby — not romance. A wrong-number text that turns into a warm daily conversation is a common opener.
- They call and text every day for weeks or months. That attention is real to you, and it is deliberate on their side.
- There is always a reason they can't meet or video call — deployed overseas, an oil rig, a hospital, a work contract abroad.
- Then: a medical emergency, a customs fee, a stuck inheritance. Or an "investment opportunity" they want to share with you.
- Never send money, gift cards, or crypto to someone you have not met in person. No exceptions, no matter how long you've talked.



Why it works

Loneliness isn't a weakness — it's a normal part of losing a spouse, moving, or outliving your friends. These crews look for exactly that, and they are patient.

If a friend here mentions someone new online, be curious and kind — not mocking. Mockery is what keeps people quiet.

The grandchild in trouble — now in their actual voice



The classic version

A panicked young voice: "Grandma? I've been in an accident / arrested. Please don't tell Mom and Dad." Then a "lawyer" or "officer" takes the phone and asks for bail money — by wire, gift card, or a courier sent to your door for cash.



What changed in 2025

They no longer have to fake the voice. A few seconds of your grandchild speaking — from a Facebook video or a voicemail greeting — is enough to clone it convincingly.



Your defense costs nothing: a family password.

- Pick a word or phrase your family would know and a stranger never would — an old pet, a street you lived on, a family joke.
- Anyone calling in an emergency has to say it. No password, no money — however much the voice sounds like them.
- Keep it off Facebook — and hang up and call the person back yourself. A cloned voice can't answer your call.

Virtual kidnapping: "We have your grandson."

Nobody has been kidnapped. The entire crime is the phone call — and it depends on you being too terrified to check.



How it runs

- Screaming in the background. Threats of violence. A demand for money right now.
- They keep you on the line so you can't call anyone — that's the whole trick.
- "Proof" may be an altered photo or AI video pulled from social media, sometimes set to disappear so you can't study it.
- Payment: wire, crypto, or a courier. The demand often drops fast if you hesitate.



What the FBI says to do

- Slow it down. Say you're writing the demand down. Their whole plan depends on speed.
- Ask to speak to them. Ask something only they'd know — the name of a pet.
- Use another phone — or the person next to you — to call or text your family right now.
- Don't give out names or details. Don't pay. Then call 911 and report to [ic3.gov](https://www.ic3.gov).

Real kidnappings for ransom are extraordinarily rare. Calls claiming one are not. Your family password works here too.

Investment scams: where the real money goes

\$3.52B

lost by older adults to investment scams in 2025 — nearly half of all elder fraud losses

\$4.35B

of elder losses involved cryptocurrency across 42,271 complaints

\$257M

lost at crypto ATMs and kiosks by people 60+ — up 58% in one year



What it looks like

- A friendly stranger, often met through a text, a dating app, or a Facebook group
- A slick app or website showing your balance climbing steadily
- Small withdrawals work perfectly — that's what earns your trust
- Then "taxes" or "fees" are owed before you can take the rest out



Three sentences that protect you

- Guaranteed returns don't exist. Anyone promising them is lying.
- No real broker asks you to buy crypto at a gas-station machine.
- Run any opportunity past your own bank or advisor first — free, and it takes ten minutes.

And then they come back for a second bite



The recovery scam

- Weeks or months after a loss, someone contacts you offering to get your money back.
- They pose as a law firm, a "fund recovery" service, a crypto tracing company, or a government agency.
- They know real details about what happened to you — because victim lists get sold and reused.
- They ask for an upfront fee, a retainer, or your account details to "return the funds."
- Nobody legitimate charges you upfront to recover stolen money. Reporting to IC3 is free.

\$540M

taken from people who had already been scammed once — reported by older adults in 2025 alone.

This is exactly why the shame has to go. A victim who tells someone is much harder to hit twice.

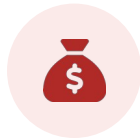
The fastest tell of all: how they want to be paid

Skip figuring out whether the story is true. Ask only: how do they want the money? Legitimate people never ask for these.



Gift cards

Read me the numbers off the back



Wire transfer

Western Union, MoneyGram, or a bank wire



Crypto or a Bitcoin ATM

"Go to the machine at the gas station"



A courier at your door

Cash or gold picked up in person



A "safe account"

Moving your own money to protect it



Payment apps to a stranger

Zelle, Venmo, or Cash App to someone you've never met

Not one of these is ever how a real bank, agency, company, or family member asks to be paid.

NOW THE GOOD NEWS

Six habits that do most of the work



Hang up and call back

On a number YOU look up — off your card, statement, or the phone book. Never the number they give you.



Set a family password

One phrase. Tonight. It defeats every voice-cloning scam at once.



Use the 24-hour rule

Any request for money waits a day. Real emergencies survive a day. Scams do not.



Name your "second opinion"

One person you call before moving money. Tell them tonight that they've got the job.



Turn on two-step login

A code texted to you when you sign in. A stolen password alone stops being enough.



Freeze your credit

Free at all three bureaus. Stops anyone opening accounts in your name.

Every one of these is free, and none of them require you to be good with computers.

Give them less to work with



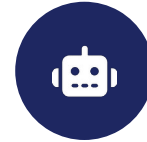
Lock your social media

Set profiles to friends-only. Remove your birth year, phone number, and home address.



Post trips afterward

Share the vacation photos when you get home — not while your apartment sits empty.



Protect their voices

Public videos of grandchildren talking are raw material for voice cloning. Ask their parents to go private.



Skip the fun quizzes

First pet? Street you grew up on? Those are the answers to your bank's security questions.



Guard your email most

Email can reset every other password you own. Give it a unique password and two-step login.



Opt out of data brokers

Removal requests are free at the big ones. An hour once a year, ideally with family helping.

You can't undo every leak — and you don't have to. You only have to be a slower, more expensive target than the next person.

Your permission slip

You are allowed to be rude to a stranger who called you. Here's your script.

"I don't do business over the phone. Goodbye."

"I'll call you back on the number on my statement."

"I never make financial decisions without my son. I'll call you back."

"If this is real, it can wait until Monday."

And you never owe anyone an explanation for hanging up. Not one word.

NO SHAME, JUST SPEED

If it happens — the first 24 hours matter most

1

Call your bank immediately

Use the number on your card. Ask for the fraud department. Money can sometimes be frozen or recalled if you're fast.

2

Disconnect the computer

If anyone had remote access, unplug it from the internet and don't use it until someone you trust checks it.

3

Change passwords, tell someone

Start with email and banking. Then tell a family member or the front desk here. Saying it out loud is the hardest and most useful step.

4

Report it — even with no loss

ic3.gov or your local FBI office. Reports are how these crews get caught, and how warnings reach the next person.

Reporting isn't about getting your money back. It's about making sure the next person in this building hears the warning.

WRITE THESE DOWN — THEY'RE ON YOUR HANDOUT TOO

Keep these four by the phone



FBI — IC3
ic3.gov

Report any internet-enabled scam, any amount, loss or no loss.



AARP Fraud Watch Helpline
877-908-3360

Free for anyone, member or not. Call to ask "is this a scam?" before you act.



Federal Trade Commission
reportfraud.ftc.gov

Identity theft and consumer fraud. Also identitytheft.gov for a recovery plan.



Texas Attorney General
texasattorneygeneral.gov

Consumer protection complaints and current Texas scam alerts.

In an emergency, or if someone is at your door demanding money: call 911 first.



You just became a hard target.

Unexpected contact. A rush of emotion. A strange way to pay.

That's the whole playbook — and you now know it better than the people they usually call.

Two calls tonight: set your family password, and name your second opinion.

And if it ever does happen to you or someone here — tell somebody fast. That's not embarrassing. That's how it stops.

Questions — and I'll stay after as long as anyone wants to talk.